

Our own data, collected over the past twenty years, repeatedly support this conclusion. Independent of college tuition, more than two-thirds of American millionaires received no economic gifts from their parents. And this includes most of those whose parents were affluent.

WEAKENING THE WEAK

So what are affluent parents to do with their wealth? How and when should they distribute it among their children? We will detail the distribution of wealth in the next chapter. But at this point, here's some food for thought: Most affluent people have at least two children. Typically, the most economically productive one receives the smaller share of his or her parent's wealth, while the least productive receives the lion's share of both economic outpatient care and inheritance.

Consider for a moment that you are a typical affluent parent. You noted that your oldest son or daughter even at an early age was extremely independent, achievement-oriented, and well disciplined. Your instinct is to nurture these traits by not trying to control his or her decisions. Instead, you spend more time helping your less resourceful child make decisions, or you actually make decisions for him. With what result? *You strengthen the strong child and weaken the weak.*

Suppose you have a ten-year-old child who goes in for a physical checkup. The examining physician tells you that your son or daughter is underweight and underdeveloped. How would you respond to this evaluation? You would find ways to improve your child's physical health. You would likely encourage your child to exercise, take vitamins, lift weights, and perhaps play sports. Most parents would attack such a problem proactively. Wouldn't you find it odd if the parent took the opposite course? How would you respond if the parent encouraged his child to eat less and exercise less?

All too often this method of weakening the weak is applied to children who show personality-related weaknesses. In one case we know about, parents were told that their son was deficient in writing and related verbal skills. How did the parents respond to this problem? First, they transferred their child to another school. The verbal deficiency problem failed to improve, however, so the father began writing his son's papers. He still writes his son's papers today. His son is a junior in college.